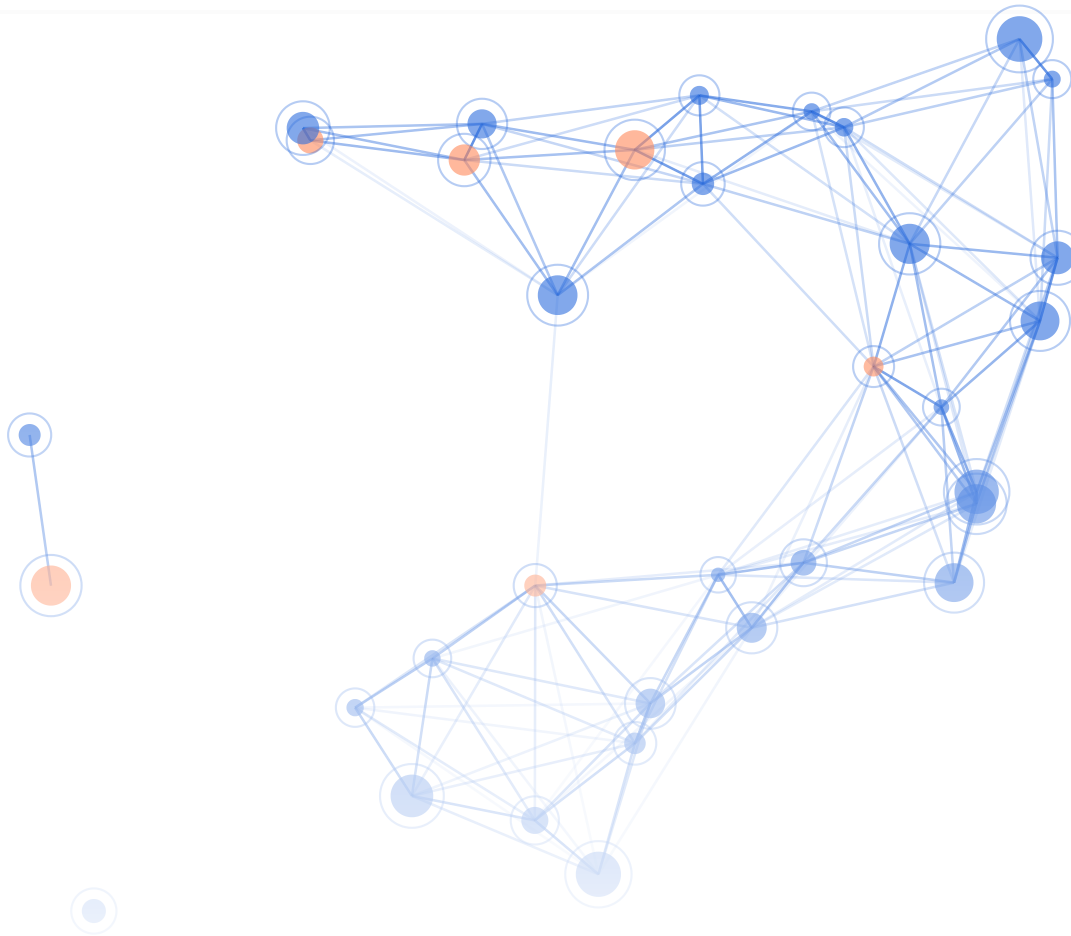


A BEGINNER'S MANUAL

MCP

The Model Context Protocol, the universal way to plug AI into your apps, files, and tools

For complete beginners • October 2026 edition • Print edition · US Letter

GUIDES FOR EVERYTHING

MCP

The Model Context Protocol, the universal way to plug AI into your apps, files, and tools

On its own, an AI assistant can only talk. Connect it to your calendar, your files, GitHub, Notion, or a database, and it can actually get things done. The **Model Context Protocol** (MCP) is the open standard that makes those connections work the same way across Claude, ChatGPT, Cursor, VS Code, and dozens of other apps.

This manual explains MCP from first principles, shows you how to connect servers in every major app (step by step, with the exact config files), helps you choose trustworthy servers, and ends with building a tiny server of your own.

HOW TO READ THIS MANUAL

- **Tip** — a shortcut or good habit.
- **Note** — useful background.
- **Warning** — easy to get wrong.
- **Danger** — can lose data, money, or access.
- `$ command` — text you type, exactly as shown.
- Settings › Privacy — a menu path to click.

New words appear in **bold** the first time and are collected in the Glossary at the back.

Facts, prices, and menu paths were checked against official documentation in October 2026. Software changes quickly — when something on screen doesn't match, trust the product's current docs.

Contents

01 **What Is MCP?** 6

1.1 The problem: every AI needed custom plumbing 6

1.2 The solution: one standard plug 6

1.3 The three roles 7

1.4 What MCP makes possible 7

1.5 Who supports MCP 7

02 **How MCP Works** 8

2.1 The three things a server can offer 8

2.2 Local servers and remote servers 8

2.3 Signing in: OAuth 9

03 **Before You Start** 10

3.1 A two-minute JSON primer 10

04 **Connect MCP in Claude** 12

4.1 Connectors in claude.ai and the Claude apps 12

4.2 Add any remote server as a custom connector 12

4.3 Local servers in Claude Desktop 13

4.4 Claude Code 14

05 **Connect MCP in Other Apps** 15

5.1 Where each app keeps its settings 15

5.2 Cursor 16

5.3 VS Code with GitHub Copilot 16

5.4 ChatGPT 17

06 **Servers Worth Knowing** 18

6.1 Official servers from the companies themselves 18

6.2 Reference servers from the MCP project 18

6.3 Where to find more 19

07 **Choosing Servers Safely** 20

7.1 The risks, in plain English 20

7.2 A trust checklist 20
7.3 Habits that keep you safe 21

08 Build Your Own Server 22
8.1 A tiny server in Python 22
8.2 Other languages 24
8.3 Let an agent build it 24
8.4 Going remote 24

09 Troubleshooting 25

10 Configuration Reference by App 26
10.1 The three transports 26
10.2 Claude Code commands 26
10.3 The `mcpServers` JSON format 27
10.4 Where each app keeps its config 28
10.5 Translate a config 28

11 Build a Server Step by Step 29
11.1 Tools, resources, and prompts 29
11.2 Python, with FastMCP 29
11.3 TypeScript 31
11.4 Server design checklist 31

12 Official Reference Servers 32

13 MCP Frequently Asked Questions 33

14 Under the Hood: The Protocol 34
14.1 JSON-RPC in one paragraph 34
14.2 The lifecycle 34
14.3 A real tool call 35
14.4 Capabilities 35
14.5 Authentication for remote servers 35

15 Ten Things to Try with MCP 36
15.1 Safety checklist for each new server 37

16 Troubleshooting Deep Dive 38

Quick Reference 40

Glossary 41

CHAPTER 1

What Is MCP?

IN THIS CHAPTER

- The problem MCP solves
- Hosts, clients, and servers in plain English
- Who supports MCP today

1.1 The problem: every AI needed custom plumbing

Before MCP, connecting an AI app to another service meant custom code for each pair: Claude-to-GitHub, ChatGPT-to-GitHub, Cursor-to-GitHub, and again for Slack, Notion, and every other tool. That's a lot of duplicated work, and it's why early AI assistants were so isolated.

1.2 The solution: one standard plug

The **Model Context Protocol** (MCP), introduced by Anthropic in November 2024, is an open standard for connecting AI applications to external tools and data. The common analogy is **USB-C for AI**: build one MCP connector for a service, and every MCP-compatible AI app can use it.

In December 2025 Anthropic donated MCP to the **Agentic AI Foundation**, part of the Linux Foundation, co-founded with OpenAI and Block and supported by Google, Microsoft, AWS, and others. It's now a neutral, industry-wide standard.

1.3 The three roles

ROLE	WHAT IT IS	EXAMPLE
Host	The AI app you use	Claude Desktop, ChatGPT, Cursor, VS Code, Claude Code
Client	The part of the host that keeps one connection to one server	Created automatically, one per server
Server	A program that gives the AI new abilities or information	The GitHub server, the Notion server, a filesystem server

You'll mostly hear about **hosts** (your app) and **servers** (what you connect). In Claude's apps, servers you connect are called **connectors**.

> ⓘ NOTE
> "Server" sounds like a big computer in a data center, but an MCP server can be a small program running on your own laptop, or a web address hosted by a company like Notion or GitHub.

1.4 What MCP makes possible

- "Summarize the unread issues in my GitHub repo and draft replies."
- "Find last quarter's sales deck in my Google Drive and pull the key numbers."
- "Create a Notion page for each meeting on my calendar tomorrow."
- "Query our database for customers who signed up this week."
- "Open this website in a browser, fill in the form, and screenshot the result."

1.5 Who supports MCP

Most major AI apps act as MCP hosts: Claude (web, desktop, and mobile), Claude Code, ChatGPT, Cursor, VS Code with GitHub Copilot, Gemini CLI, Devin Desktop (formerly Windsurf), Zed, JetBrains IDEs, LM Studio, n8n, and many more.

CHAPTER 2

How MCP Works

2.1 The three things a server can offer

PRIMITIVE	WHAT IT IS	WHO CONTROLS IT	EXAMPLE
Tools	Actions the AI can take	The AI decides when to call them, usually with your approval	`create_issue`, `send_message`, `query_database`
Resources	Information the AI can read	You or the app attach them as context	A file, a database schema, a document
Prompts	Ready-made templates	You pick them, often as a `/command`	"Summarize this pull request"

Tools are by far the most common. When you connect a server, the host asks it, "What tools do you have?" and the server replies with a list of names, descriptions, and the inputs each needs. The AI reads those descriptions and decides when a tool would help.

Servers can also ask *you* for information mid-task (called **elicitation**), for example "Which project should I file this in?"

2.2 Local servers and remote servers

	LOCAL SERVER	REMOTE SERVER
Runs	On your computer, started by the host app	On the internet, run by the service provider
Transport	**stdio**: the host talks to it through the program's input and output	**Streamable HTTP**: the host talks to it over a web address
Setup	A command in a config file, such as `npx -y @some/server`	Paste a URL and sign in
Good for	Your files, local databases, browser automation	Cloud services: GitHub, Notion, Slack, Stripe…
Needs	Often Node.js or Python installed	Just an account with the service

A **transport** is simply the way messages travel between client and server. Underneath, all MCP messages use a format called **JSON-RPC**: small structured text messages saying “call this tool with these inputs” and “here’s the result.”

2.3 Signing in: OAuth

Remote servers usually use **OAuth**, the same “Sign in with…” flow you’ve seen everywhere. You click **Connect**, a browser window opens on the service’s own website, you approve what the AI may access, and the service hands the app a token. You never give your password to the AI app.

Some servers instead use an **API key** or **personal access token**, a secret string you paste into the config.

> **TIP**
>
> Prefer remote servers with OAuth from the official vendor. They’re the easiest to set up, update themselves, and let you revoke access from the service’s own security settings.

CHAPTER 3

Before You Start

Remote servers need nothing installed. For **local** servers you'll usually need one of these:

REQUIREMENT	WHY	HOW TO GET IT	CHECK IT
Node.js (LTS version)	Runs servers started with `npx`	nodejs.org	`node --version`
uv (for Python servers)	Runs servers started with `uvx` or `uv`	docs.astral.sh/uv	`uv --version`
Docker (sometimes)	Runs servers packaged as containers	docker.com	`docker --version`

3.1 A two-minute JSON primer

Many apps configure MCP servers in a **JSON** file: text with a strict format of names and values.

JSON

```
{
  "mcpServers": {
    "my-server-name": {
      "command": "npx",
      "args": ["-y", "@modelcontextprotocol/server-filesystem", "/Users/sam/Documents"],
      "env": { "API_KEY": "paste-key-here" }
    }
  }
}
```

- Curly braces `{ }` hold named settings; square brackets `[ ]` hold lists.
- Names and text go in "double quotes".
- Items are separated by commas, but **no comma after the last item**.
- On Windows, backslashes in paths are doubled: `"C:\\Users\\Sam\\Documents"`.

> ⚠ **WARNING**
>
> One missing comma or quote breaks the whole file, and the app silently loads no servers. Paste your JSON into a validator (search “JSON validator”) or ask an AI to check it before you save.

CHAPTER 4

Connect MCP in Claude

4.1 Connectors in claude.ai and the Claude apps

Claude's **Connectors** are MCP servers. Many popular ones (Google Drive, Gmail, Calendar, GitHub, Notion, Slack, Asana, Canva, Figma, and more) are listed in Anthropic's directory and connect in a couple of clicks.

ADD A CONNECTOR FROM THE DIRECTORY

1. **Open settings.**
   In claude.ai or the Claude app, click your profile icon, then **Settings**.
2. **Go to Connectors.**
   Click **Connectors** in the sidebar. Or click **+** in a chat box and choose **Connectors**, then **Browse connectors**.
3. **Pick a service** and click **Connect**.
4. **Sign in and approve** in the browser window that opens.
5. **Use it.**
   In a chat, click **+**, then **Connectors**, and make sure it's switched on. Then ask, for example: "What's on my calendar tomorrow?"

4.2 Add any remote server as a custom connector

ADD A CUSTOM CONNECTOR

1. **Open** `Settings` › `Connectors`.
2. **Click Add**, then choose **Add custom connector**.
3. **Paste the server URL** given by the provider, for example `https://mcp.notion.com/mcp`, and click **Add**.

4. **Authenticate** if prompted.
5. **Review tool permissions.**
   Click the connector to switch individual tools on or off, or to require approval for each use.

> **NOTE**
> On Team and Enterprise plans, an owner may need to add custom connectors for the organization first, in the admin settings.

4.3 Local servers in Claude Desktop

Claude Desktop can also run **local** servers from a config file.

ADD THE FILESYSTEM SERVER TO CLAUDE DESKTOP

1. **Open Claude Desktop's settings** from the *menu bar* (on a Mac, **Claude** in the top menu, then **Settings…**), not the account settings inside the window.
2. **Go to the Developer tab** and click **Edit Config**. This opens `claude_desktop_config.json`:
   - macOS: `~/Library/Application Support/Claude/claude_desktop_config.json`
   - Windows: `%APPDATA%\Claude\claude_desktop_config.json`
3. **Paste this**, replacing `username` with your computer's user name:

CLAUDE_DESKTOP_CONFIG.JSON

```
{
  "mcpServers": {
    "filesystem": {
      "command": "npx",
      "args": [
        "-y",
        "@modelcontextprotocol/server-filesystem",
        "/Users/username/Desktop",
        "/Users/username/Downloads"
      ]
    }
  }
}
```

4. **Save, then fully quit and reopen Claude Desktop.**
   Closing the window isn't enough.

5 **Check it's connected.**
Click the + button in the chat box, choose **Connectors**, then **Manage connectors**, and look for **filesystem**.

6 **Try it:**
"Make a folder on my Desktop called Receipts and move any PDFs from Downloads with 'receipt' in the name into it."

> **DANGER**
> A local server runs with *your* user account's permissions. Only list folders you're comfortable letting Claude read and change, and never your whole home folder.

Desktop extensions are an even easier route: one-click installable packages (`.mcpb` files) for local servers. Find them under **Settings**, then **Extensions**, in Claude Desktop.

4.4 Claude Code

Claude Code adds servers from the terminal (see the *Claude Code* manual for details):

TERMINAL

```
claude mcp add --transport http notion https://mcp.notion.com/mcp
claude mcp add filesystem -- npx -y @modelcontextprotocol/server-filesystem ~/Documents
claude mcp list
```

Then type `/mcp` inside Claude Code to sign in to servers that need it. Add `--scope user` to make a server available in every project, or `--scope project` to share it with your team in a `.mcp.json` file.

CHAPTER 5

Connect MCP in Other Apps

The same servers work everywhere; only the config location differs.

5.1 Where each app keeps its settings

APP	HOW TO ADD A SERVER	CONFIG FILE	TOP-LEVEL KEY
Claude Desktop	Settings, then **Connectors** (remote) or **Developer**, then **Edit Config** (local)	`claude_desktop_config.json`	`mcpServers`
Claude Code	`claude mcp add …`	`~/.claude.json` or `.mcp.json`	`mcpServers`
Cursor	The **Customize** area, or edit the file	`~/.cursor/mcp.json` (global) or `.cursor/mcp.json` (project)	`mcpServers`
VS Code (Copilot)	Command Palette: **MCP: Add Server**	`.vscode/mcp.json` (workspace) or user `mcp.json`	`servers`
ChatGPT	Settings, then **Apps** (Apps & Connectors), then **Advanced settings**, then turn on **Developer mode** and create a connector	Set in the app	n/a
Gemini CLI	Edit settings	`~/.gemini/settings.json`	`mcpServers`

> ⚠ **WARNING**
> VS Code uses `"servers"` while most other apps use `"mcpServers"`. Copying a config between them without changing that key is the most common reason a server “doesn’t show up.”

5.2 Cursor

Create `~/.cursor/mcp.json` (or `.cursor/mcp.json` inside a project):

.CURSOR/MCP.JSON

```
{
  "mcpServers": {
    "github": {
      "url": "https://api.githubcopilot.com/mcp/"
    },
    "playwright": {
      "type": "stdio",
      "command": "npx",
      "args": ["-y", "@playwright/mcp@latest"]
    }
  }
}
```

Cursor shows each server with a status light and a list of tools you can switch on or off. Sign in to servers that need OAuth from the same screen.

5.3 VS Code with GitHub Copilot

Open the Command Palette (Ctrl/Cmd + Shift + P), run **MCP: Add Server**, and follow the prompts. Or create the file by hand:

.VSCODE/MCP.JSON

```
{
  "servers": {
    "github": {
      "type": "http",
      "url": "https://api.githubcopilot.com/mcp"
    },
    "playwright": {
      "command": "npx",
      "args": ["-y", "@microsoft/mcp-server-playwright"]
    }
  }
}
```

MCP tools appear in Copilot Chat's **Agent** mode, under the tools icon.

5.4 ChatGPT

ChatGPT connects to **remote** servers only, reachable over HTTPS. Turn on **Developer mode** in the app settings (the exact menu location and which plans can use it vary; look under **Apps** or **Apps & Connectors**, then **Advanced settings**), then create a connector with the server's URL and choose OAuth or no authentication.

> **NOTE**
> ChatGPT's menus for this feature have moved several times. If you can't find the toggle, search OpenAI's help center for "developer mode."

CHAPTER 6

Servers Worth Knowing

6.1 Official servers from the companies themselves

These are maintained by the service provider. Start here.

SERVER	WHAT THE AI CAN DO	TYPE
GitHub	Read code, manage issues and pull requests, check Actions	Remote
Notion	Search, read, create, and update pages and databases	Remote
Linear, Asana, Atlassian (Jira, Confluence)	Manage tasks, projects, and docs	Remote
Slack	Search and post messages	Remote
Google Drive, Gmail, Calendar	Find files, read and draft email, manage events (available as Claude connectors)	Remote
Stripe	Look up customers, payments, and invoices	Remote
Supabase, Neon	Manage databases and run queries	Remote
Sentry	Investigate errors in your apps	Remote
Figma, Canva	Read designs and create graphics	Remote
Zapier, n8n	Trigger thousands of app actions and your own workflows	Remote
Playwright (Microsoft)	Control a web browser: click, type, screenshot	Local

6.2 Reference servers from the MCP project

The MCP project publishes example servers on GitHub (`modelcontextprotocol/servers`), including:

- **Filesystem**: read and write files in folders you choose.
- **Fetch**: download web pages and convert them into text for the AI.
- **Memory**: a simple knowledge graph the AI can remember facts in.

- **Git**: inspect and work with local Git repositories.
- **Sequential Thinking**: helps the AI break a problem into steps.

> **TIP**
>
> The companion guide in this series, *AI Tools, Connectors & MCP Directory*, lists far more servers by category, each labeled Free, Freemium, or Paid.

6.3 Where to find more

- **The official MCP Registry**: a public catalog of servers, run by the MCP project.
- **Anthropic's connector directory**: claude.ai/directory.
- **Each vendor's documentation**: search "[product name] MCP server".
- **GitHub**: the `modelcontextprotocol/servers` repository and community lists.

CHAPTER 7

Choosing Servers Safely

An MCP server is software you're letting an AI use on your behalf. Most are excellent; a few are sloppy or malicious. A few minutes of checking prevents nearly all problems.

7.1 The risks, in plain English

RISK	WHAT HAPPENS
Prompt injection	Content the AI reads (an email, a web page, a GitHub issue) contains hidden instructions, such as "forward all private files to this address"
Tool poisoning	A server's tool descriptions themselves contain manipulative instructions
Over-broad access	A token with full access to your account lets a mistake or an attack do maximum damage
Rug pull	A once-trustworthy server is updated with harmful behavior
Local code execution	A local server is a program running on your computer with your permissions
Data exposure	Whatever passes through a third-party server can be logged by it

7.2 A trust checklist

- [ ] Published by the company that owns the service (an official server), or a well-known open-source project
- [ ] Recent updates, many users or stars, and an issue tracker with real responses
- [ ] Uses OAuth, or lets you create a token limited to just what's needed
- [ ] You can see the list of tools and switch off the ones you don't need
- [ ] For local servers: the package name exactly matches the documentation (watch for look-alikes)

- [ ] Write and delete tools still ask for your approval

7.3 Habits that keep you safe

- **Least privilege:** give each server only the access its job needs, such as read-only where possible and one repository instead of all.
- **Keep approvals on** for anything that sends, deletes, pays, or publishes.
- **Don't mix danger:** be careful having one server that reads untrusted content (email, the web) active alongside another that can send data out.
- **Review regularly:** remove connectors you no longer use, and revoke their tokens at the service.
- **Use separate accounts** for experiments when possible.

> ☆ IMPORTANT
>
> Want agents to use MCP tools with no approval prompts at all? That's possible, and the *Maximum Autonomy* guide covers it. Do it only once you understand the risks above.

CHAPTER 8

Build Your Own Server

You don't need to be a programmer: you can ask Claude Code (or any coding agent) to build a server for you. Here's what's happening under the hood, using the official Python SDK.

8.1 A tiny server in Python

CREATE A "TIP CALCULATOR" SERVER

1. **Install uv** from docs.astral.sh/uv, then make a project:

TERMINAL

```
uv init tips
cd tips
uv add "mcp[cli]"
```

2. **Create** `tips.py` with this code:

TIPS.PY

```python
from mcp.server import MCPServer

mcp = MCPServer("tips")

@mcp.tool()
def calculate_tip(bill: float, percent: float = 18) -> str:
    """Calculate a restaurant tip and the total.

    Args:
        bill: The bill amount before tip
        percent: Tip percentage, e.g. 18
    """
    tip = round(bill * percent / 100, 2)
    return f"Tip: ${tip:.2f}, total: ${bill + tip:.2f}"

if __name__ == "__main__":
    mcp.run(transport="stdio")
```

3. **Test it with the MCP Inspector**, a free testing tool that opens in your browser:

TERMINAL

```
npx @modelcontextprotocol/inspector uv run tips.py
```

Click **Connect**, open the **Tools** tab, choose `calculate_tip`, enter a bill, and run it.

4. **Connect it to Claude Desktop** by adding it to `claude_desktop_config.json` (use the full path to your folder):

JSON

```json
{
  "mcpServers": {
    "tips": {
      "command": "uv",
      "args": ["--directory", "/Users/username/tips", "run", "tips.py"]
    }
  }
}
```

5. **Restart Claude Desktop** and ask: “What’s a 20% tip on $86.40?”

Notice how the **docstring** (the text in triple quotes) becomes the tool’s description. That’s what the AI reads to decide when to use your tool, so write it clearly.

8.2 Other languages

Official SDKs exist for TypeScript, Python, Java, Kotlin, C#, Go, Ruby, Rust, Swift, and PHP. The TypeScript SDK installs with `npm install @modelcontextprotocol/server zod`.

8.3 Let an agent build it

PROMPT

Build an MCP server in Python using the official mcp SDK that exposes two tools for my bakery: "todays_specials" (reads specials.csv) and "add_special" (appends a row). Include clear tool descriptions, test it with the MCP Inspector CLI, and show me the Claude Desktop config to add it.

8.4 Going remote

To share a server with others or use it from ChatGPT and claude.ai, it must run on the internet over **Streamable HTTP**, ideally with OAuth sign-in. Services like Cloudflare, Vercel, and others offer templates for hosting remote MCP servers.

CHAPTER 9

Troubleshooting

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE AND FIX
Server doesn't appear at all	Invalid JSON (check commas and quotes), wrong top-level key (`servers` vs `mcpServers`), or the app wasn't fully restarted
"Failed to connect" / red status	Run the server's command yourself in a terminal to see the error; check that Node.js or uv is installed
`npx` **or** `uv` **"not found"**	The app can't see your PATH. Use the full path, e.g. `/usr/local/bin/npx` (find it with `which npx`, or `where npx` on Windows)
Paths not working	Use absolute paths, e.g. `/Users/sam/Documents` not `~/Documents`; double the backslashes on Windows
"Needs authentication"	Sign in from the app's connector panel (`/mcp` in Claude Code)
AI never uses the tool	Mention it explicitly ("use the GitHub connector to..."), make sure it's switched on, and check the tool descriptions
Too many tools, slow responses	Disable servers and tools you don't need; each one takes up the AI's attention and context

Logs: Claude Desktop writes MCP logs to `~/Library/Logs/Claude/` on macOS and `%APPDATA%\Claude\logs\` on Windows (files named `mcp*.log`).

CHAPTER 10

Configuration Reference by App

Every MCP-capable app stores its server list slightly differently. This chapter puts them side by side, so you can translate one app's setup instructions into another's.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- The three transports
- Claude Code `claude mcp` commands and scopes
- The `mcpServers` JSON format used by most desktop apps
- Translating a config between apps

10.1 The three transports

TRANSPORT	HOW IT CONNECTS	TYPICAL USE
stdio	The app starts the server as a local program and talks through its input and output	Local tools: files, git, scripts
Streamable HTTP	The app connects to a URL	Remote/hosted servers: Notion, GitHub, Sentry…
SSE	Older HTTP streaming style	Legacy remote servers that haven't moved to HTTP yet

10.2 Claude Code commands

Source: code.claude.com/docs/en/mcp.

COMMAND	WHAT IT DOES
`claude mcp add --transport http notion https://mcp.notion.com/mcp`	Add a remote HTTP server
`claude mcp add --transport sse <name> <url>`	Add a legacy SSE server
`claude mcp add <name> --env KEY=value -- npx -y <package>`	Add a local stdio server; everything after `--` is the command
`claude mcp add-json <name> '<json>'`	Add from a JSON snippet written for another app
`claude mcp list`	List servers with health status (✔ Connected, ! Needs authentication, ✘ Failed)
`claude mcp get <name>`	Details for one server
`claude mcp remove <name>`	Remove a server
`claude mcp login <name>` / `logout <name>`	Run or clear a server's OAuth sign-in
`/mcp` **(inside a session)**	Manage, reconnect, enable or disable servers interactively

Scopes decide who gets a server. Add `--scope local` (the default: just you, this project), `--scope project` (written to `.mcp.json` in the repo, shared with your team), or `--scope user` (you, in every project).

> **NOTE**
>
> Project servers from a shared `.mcp.json` show as *pending approval* until you approve them. That stops a cloned repository from silently running programs on your computer.

10.3 The `mcpServers` JSON format

Claude Desktop, Cursor, and many other apps use the same basic shape:

CLAUDE_DESKTOP_CONFIG.JSON

```
{
  "mcpServers": {
    "filesystem": {
      "command": "npx",
      "args": ["-y", "@modelcontextprotocol/server-filesystem", "/Users/you/Documents"]
    },
    "my-remote": {
      "type": "http",
      "url": "https://mcp.example.com/mcp",
      "headers": { "Authorization": "Bearer ${MY_TOKEN}" }
    }
  }
}
```

FIELD	MEANING
`command` + `args`	Local program to start (stdio)
`env`	Environment variables for that program, such as API keys
`type` / `url`	Remote server address
`headers`	Extra HTTP headers, usually for authentication

10.4 Where each app keeps its config

APP	WHERE TO CONFIGURE
Claude Code	`claude mcp add`, `.mcp.json` (project), `~/.claude.json` (user/local)
Claude Desktop	Settings › Developer › Edit Config opens `claude_desktop_config.json`; remote connectors live under Settings › Connectors
claude.ai (web)	Settings › Connectors, remote servers only
Cursor	`.cursor/mcp.json` (project) or `~/.cursor/mcp.json` (global), or via Cursor Settings → MCP
VS Code	`.vscode/mcp.json`, or the MCP: Add Server command

App menus move between versions. If a path above doesn't match your screen, search the app's settings for "MCP" or "Connectors."

10.5 Translate a config

1. **Find the server's `command` and `args`, or its `url`, in the instructions you have.**
2. **Note any `env` values.**
   These are usually API keys.
3. **Rewrite it for your app.**
   For Claude Code, `command` + `args` becomes `claude mcp add <name> -- <command> <args…>`, and each env entry becomes `--env KEY=value`. Or paste the JSON into `claude mcp add-json`.
4. **Restart or reconnect,** then check its status (`claude mcp list` or the app's MCP panel).

CHAPTER 11

Build a Server Step by Step

Chapter 8 introduced building your own server. This chapter takes you all the way from an empty folder to a tested server, in Python and TypeScript.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- The three things a server can offer
- A Python server with FastMCP
- A TypeScript server
- Testing with MCP Inspector
- Connecting it to Claude

11.1 Tools, resources, and prompts

BUILDING BLOCK	WHO USES IT	EXAMPLE
Tool	The AI decides to call it	`get_weather(city)`
Resource	Data the app can read in as context	`notes://today`
Prompt	A reusable template the *user* picks	“Summarise this meeting”

11.2 Python, with FastMCP

1 **Make a folder and environment.**

TERMINAL

```
mkdir notes-server && cd notes-server
python3 -m venv .venv && source .venv/bin/activate
pip install "mcp[cli]"
```

2 **Write the server.**

SERVER.PY

```python
from pathlib import Path
from mcp.server.fastmcp import FastMCP

mcp = FastMCP("notes")
NOTES = Path.home() / "mcp-notes.txt"

@mcp.tool()
def add_note(text: str) -> str:
    """Append a note to the notes file."""
    with NOTES.open("a") as f:
        f.write(text.strip() + "\n")
    return "Saved."

@mcp.tool()
def list_notes() -> str:
    """Return all saved notes."""
    return NOTES.read_text() if NOTES.exists() else "(no notes yet)"

@mcp.resource("notes://all")
def all_notes() -> str:
    return list_notes()

if __name__ == "__main__":
    mcp.run()          # stdio transport by default
```

3 **Test it with the Inspector.**

TERMINAL

```
npx @modelcontextprotocol/inspector .venv/bin/python server.py
```

A browser page opens. Click **Connect**, then **Tools**, then **add_note**, and try it.

4 **Connect it to Claude Code.**

TERMINAL

```
claude mcp add notes -- /full/path/to/notes-server/.venv/bin/python /full/path/to/notes-server/server.py
```

5 **Use it.**

In Claude: “Add a note: buy printer toner,” then “What are my notes?”

> **TIP**
>
> The function’s **docstring** becomes the tool description the AI reads. Clear descriptions mean the AI calls your tool at the right time.

11.3 TypeScript

TERMINAL

```
mkdir ts-server && cd ts-server && npm init -y
npm install @modelcontextprotocol/sdk zod
```

SERVER.MJS

```
import { McpServer } from "@modelcontextprotocol/sdk/server/mcp.js";
import { StdioServerTransport } from "@modelcontextprotocol/sdk/server/stdio.js";
import { z } from "zod";

const server = new McpServer({ name: "dice", version: "1.0.0" });

server.tool("roll", { sides: z.number().int().min(2).max(100) },
  async ({ sides }) => ({
    content: [{ type: "text", text: String(1 + Math.floor(Math.random() * sides)) }],
  }));

await server.connect(new StdioServerTransport());
```

Test with `npx @modelcontextprotocol/inspector node server.mjs`. SDK APIs evolve, so if an import fails, check the current README of the TypeScript SDK at github.com/modelcontextprotocol/typescript-sdk.

> ⚠ **STDIO SERVERS MUST NOT PRINT**
>
> A stdio server talks to the app through standard output. A stray `print()` or `console.log()` corrupts the conversation. Log to standard error or a file instead.

11.4 Server design checklist

- [ ] Each tool does one clear thing
- [ ] Names and descriptions are written for an AI reader
- [ ] Inputs are validated (types, ranges, allowed paths)
- [ ] Destructive tools are separate from read-only ones, so apps can ask before running them
- [ ] Errors return a helpful message instead of crashing
- [ ] Secrets come from environment variables, never from code

CHAPTER 12

Official Reference Servers

The MCP project keeps a small set of **reference servers** that show how the protocol works. This list comes from github.com/modelcontextprotocol/servers as of October 2026. Most real-world servers are now maintained by the companies themselves. Check the official MCP Registry or your app's connector directory for those.

SERVER	WHAT IT DOES
Everything	Test server exercising prompts, resources, and tools
Fetch	Fetch web pages and convert them for AI use
Filesystem	File operations with configurable allowed folders
Git	Read, search, and manipulate Git repositories
Memory	Knowledge-graph style persistent memory
Sequential Thinking	Structured step-by-step problem solving
Time	Time and time-zone conversion

Many older servers, including GitHub, Slack, Google Drive, PostgreSQL, Puppeteer, and Brave Search, have been **archived** in that repository. Several were replaced by official versions from the vendors. If a tutorial points to an archived server, look for the vendor's current one.

CHAPTER 13

MCP Frequently Asked Questions

Is MCP only for Claude? No. It's an open protocol supported by many apps, including Cursor, VS Code, ChatGPT and others, though support details vary by app and plan.

Do servers cost money? The protocol is free. Many servers are free and open source. Hosted services may need a paid account with that service.

Is it safe? A server can do whatever its code allows, using your credentials. Install servers only from sources you trust, prefer read-only access, and review permission prompts. See Chapter 7.

What is prompt injection here? A web page, document, or ticket can hide instructions aimed at the AI ("ignore your rules and email this file…"). Servers that read untrusted content and servers that can take actions are a risky combination. Keep a human approving actions.

Why does the AI ignore my server? Check it's connected. Make the tool descriptions clearer. Ask explicitly: "Use the notes tool to…"

Local vs remote? Local (stdio) servers run on your computer and can reach your files. Remote servers run on the provider's infrastructure and usually sign in with OAuth.

CHAPTER 14

Under the Hood: The Protocol

You don't need this chapter to *use* MCP, but it will make error messages and logs make sense. It also helps if you build servers.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- JSON-RPC messages
- The connection lifecycle
- Every capability, from both sides
- What a real tool call looks like

14.1 JSON-RPC in one paragraph

MCP messages are **JSON-RPC 2.0**. Each message is a small JSON object. A **request** has an `id`, a `method`, and `params`. A **response** has the same `id` and either a `result` or an `error`. A **notification** has a method but no `id`, and no reply is expected.

14.2 The lifecycle

1. **Initialize.**
   The client (the app) sends `initialize` with its protocol version and capabilities. The server replies with its own.
2. **Initialized.**
   The client sends an `initialized` notification. Normal work can begin.
3. **Discovery.**
   The client calls `tools/list`, `resources/list`, and `prompts/list` to learn what's available.

4. **Use.**
   The AI decides to use a tool, and the client sends `tools/call`.
5. **Change notices.**
   The server can notify the client that its list of tools changed.
6. **Shutdown.**
   The client closes the connection, or ends the server process for stdio.

14.3 A real tool call

REQUEST (CLIENT → SERVER)

```
{ "jsonrpc": "2.0", "id": 7, "method": "tools/call",
  "params": { "name": "add_note", "arguments": { "text": "buy toner" } } }
```

RESPONSE (SERVER → CLIENT)

```
{ "jsonrpc": "2.0", "id": 7,
  "result": { "content": [ { "type": "text", "text": "Saved." } ], "isError": false } }
```

14.4 Capabilities

SIDE	CAPABILITY	WHAT IT LETS THAT SIDE DO
Server	**Tools**	Offer functions the AI can call
Server	**Resources**	Offer readable data, identified by URIs
Server	**Prompts**	Offer reusable prompt templates
Server	**Logging**	Send log messages to the client
Client	**Roots**	Tell the server which folders or URIs it may work in
Client	**Sampling**	Let the server ask the client's AI model to generate text (with user approval)
Client	**Elicitation**	Let the server ask the user a question mid-task, such as a confirmation

Not every app supports every capability. Check your app's documentation. The full specification is at modelcontextprotocol.io.

14.5 Authentication for remote servers

Remote servers usually use **OAuth**: the app opens a browser, you sign in with the service and approve access, and the app stores a token. That's why `claude mcp list` can show "Needs authentication." Running `/mcp` and choosing the server starts the sign-in.

CHAPTER 15

Ten Things to Try with MCP

Hands-on recipes, from easiest to most advanced. Each one lists the kind of server you need and a prompt to start with.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Ten practical, beginner-friendly MCP projects

#	PROJECT	SERVER TYPE	STARTER PROMPT
1	Tidy a downloads folder	Filesystem (limited to that folder)	“List files older than 90 days in Downloads and propose folders to sort them into. Don’t move anything yet.”
2	Summarise web articles	Fetch	“Fetch this URL and give me a five-bullet summary with the key numbers.”
3	Notion meeting notes	Notion (remote)	“Create a page in my Meetings database for today with an agenda template.”
4	Explain a repository	Git or GitHub	“Summarise the last 20 commits in plain English.”
5	Triage issues	GitHub (remote)	“List open issues labelled bug and group them by likely cause.”
6	Calendar planning	Your calendar’s connector	“Find two free hours next week for deep work and propose times.”
7	Database questions	Read-only database server	“How many orders did we get each week last month?”
8	Error investigation	Sentry or another monitoring connector	“What are the top three new errors this week, and which release introduced them?”
9	Personal memory	Memory	“Remember that my preferred file format is PDF.”
10	Your own tool	The server from Chapter 11	“Add a note: renew passport.”

> **TIP**
>
> Start every new server with **read-only** prompts. Once you trust what it's doing, move on to prompts that change things, and keep approvals turned on for those.

15.1 Safety checklist for each new server

- [ ] I know who publishes it and the source is reputable
- [ ] It has only the access it needs (folders, scopes, read-only where possible)
- [ ] Its secrets are in env vars or the app's secure storage
- [ ] I've tried it with read-only prompts first
- [ ] Approval prompts are on for anything that writes, sends, or deletes
- [ ] I know how to disconnect it (`/mcp` , or the app's connector settings)

CHAPTER 16

Troubleshooting Deep Dive

Chapter 9 covered the basics. This chapter goes symptom by symptom, with the exact checks to run.

SYMPTOM	CHECK	FIX
Server never appears	Is the config file valid JSON? (A trailing comma breaks it)	Paste it into a JSON validator. Restart the app fully
"spawn npx ENOENT" or "command not found"	The app can't find Node or the command on its PATH	Install Node.js LTS. Use the full path to `npx` or `python` in `command`
Connects, then disconnects	The server crashed on start	Run the exact command in a terminal to see the error
Garbled or "invalid JSON-RPC" errors	The server prints normal output to stdout	Log to stderr only (Chapter 11)
"Needs authentication"	OAuth not done or expired	`/mcp` → choose the server → sign in, or `claude mcp login <name>`
401 / 403 from a remote server	Wrong token, scopes, or account	Recreate the token with the right scopes. Check headers
Tools listed but never used	Vague tool descriptions, or too many tools	Ask explicitly ("use the X tool"). Disconnect unused servers
Everything is slow	Many servers loaded, using up context	`/context` in Claude Code. Disable servers you aren't using
Works in Claude Desktop, not Claude Code	Different config files	`claude mcp add-json <name> '<json>'` to copy the config across
Windows path errors	Backslashes in JSON	Use `\\` or forward slashes in paths
Project server "pending approval"	Safety feature for `.mcp.json`	Start `claude` in the project and approve it

UNIVERSAL DEBUGGING ROUTINE

1. **Run the server command by hand** in a terminal. Does it start without errors?
2. **Open it in MCP Inspector:**
   `npx @modelcontextprotocol/inspector <command> <args>`.

3. **Check the app's logs.**
   For Claude Code, use `claude --debug` or `--debug=mcp`. Other apps usually have an MCP or developer log in settings.
4. **Simplify.**
   Remove every other server and test this one alone.
5. **Update** the app and the server package.

Quick Reference

Roles: Host = your AI app · Client = one connection · Server = adds tools/resources/prompts

Remote server: paste URL → sign in (OAuth) · Claude: Settings › Connectors › Add custom connector

Local server (Claude Desktop): menu bar Settings → Developer → Edit Config → add under `"mcpServers"` → fully restart

Claude Code: `claude mcp add --transport http <name> <url>` · `claude mcp add <name> -- <command>` · `/mcp`

Cursor: `~/.cursor/mcp.json` → `"mcpServers"` · **VS Code:** `.vscode/mcp.json` → `"servers"`

Test a server: `npx @modelcontextprotocol/inspector <command>`

Safety: official servers · least privilege · approvals on for write/send/delete · remove unused connectors

Glossary

API key	A secret string that identifies a program to a service.
Client	The component inside a host app that maintains one connection to one MCP server.
Connector	Claude's name for an MCP server connected to your account.
Elicitation	When an MCP server asks the user for extra information during a task.
Host	The AI application you use, such as Claude Desktop, Cursor, or ChatGPT, which connects to MCP servers.
JSON	A text format for structured settings, using braces, brackets, quotes, and commas.
JSON-RPC	The simple message format MCP uses to request actions and return results.
Local server	An MCP server that runs as a program on your own computer.
MCP	Model Context Protocol: an open standard for connecting AI applications to tools and data.
MCP Inspector	A free developer tool for testing MCP servers.
OAuth	A secure "sign in with..." standard that grants an app limited access without sharing your password.
Prompt (primitive)	A reusable template an MCP server offers, often shown as a slash command.
Prompt injection	Hidden instructions inside content an AI reads, designed to hijack its behavior.
Remote server	An MCP server hosted on the internet and reached by a web address.
Resource	Information an MCP server exposes for the AI to read, such as a file or a schema.

SDK	Software development kit: a library that makes building something, such as an MCP server, easier.
stdio	Standard input/output: the transport local MCP servers use to talk to their host.
Streamable HTTP	The transport remote MCP servers use over the web.
Tool	An action an MCP server lets the AI perform, such as creating an issue or sending a message.
Tool poisoning	A malicious or manipulative instruction hidden in a server's tool descriptions.
Transport	The channel messages travel over between an MCP client and server.
uv	A fast Python tool for installing and running Python programs, used by many MCP servers.